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Talking to Teddy

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Talking to Teddy
By Jillian Carpenter

Oh… hello! I'm Mary. It's nice to meet you. You'll have to excuse me a little bit. I haven't had guests over in quite some time. *(show picture)* This is Robert. I know I know we look "just like twins." He used to hate when people said that about us. He always wanted to look just like his father. Of course, there's nothing wrong with that but you know. Still burns a little bit. Never really was a mama's boy. Oh, I almost forgot. This is Teddy, Robert's best friend. He took him everywhere with him. School, home you name it. As a matter of fact, I used to have to fix Teddy a small plate of dinner, make sure Teddy's teeth were brushed every night, make sure he was ready for school… everything. He loved that bear so much that that crazy boy took him in the bath when he was little so Teddy wouldn't be alone for a second. He loved that bear so much. He would talk to him about anything and everything and sometimes when it was just us in the house, I almost think I could hear Teddy respond. I promise I am not crazy. You can probably spot Teddy in every picture I have of Robbie when he was little. They were best friends. Practically brothers. But as he got older and older, people started to get concerned about him.

"Mary, that boy is 16 years old, and he still carries that thing around? Isn't that a little strange?" Or
"When my son wouldn't give up his pacifier, the doctor said it might be best to take it from him. Think you should do that with that bear?"

People all over town would worry and worry about him...but I wasn't gonna take it away. That was his best friend… his outlet.

You see… Robert had a hard time during school. His grades were…okay, I guess. But that wasn't what I was worried about. He… my baby didn't have any friends. He wasn't a social butterfly and the other kids saw that. He tried so hard to make friends with them but…nothing. There were no playdates or study groups. Every birthday came and went without a party full of friends. It was always just him and Teddy.

I used to get so upset when we'd see kids from school hanging out without him. Like they would always say no to my son but make plans with their little buddies to exclude him. I don't think it bothered him as much as me though. He used to see how frustrated I'd get and say "Mama don't be mad. I don't need them. I've got you and dad and Teddy and that's all I need." I love how clever he is.

Like I said earlier his grades were… okay. He wasn't failing terribly but I don't think that Harvard was gonna be knocking on his door anytime soon. His counselors at school called me in

one day to discuss his grades and his future, and as they told me how concerned they were about him; I couldn't help but look back at my son. His sweet little innocent happy face said everything to me. He was trying so hard, and they were not seeing it. They would say things like

"Maam we are really worried about Robert. If he keeps this trend up his future is not gonna look bright."

With this, I could only stop and listen. They went on and on and on about how he was not gonna amount to anything or how I should probably search his bedroom for drugs or some such nonsense. But I knew that if I started to fight back, I would say something I regretted. So, I didn't. I was raised better than that.

This all went on for months. Week after week Robbie would come home disappointed because his tests were not what he thought they would be, but I tried to get him to look on the bright side. While they weren't what he thought they were, they definitely got better. He would come home every day from school and try to get Teddy to help him with his homework. Who knows, maybe it helped? People started planning graduation parties and we only got one invite from my friend Janet. Her daughter was head of the soccer team and she felt bad leaving him out. I tried to get him to go just so he could enjoy his last night out with his class, but he refused. He wanted to spend it watching movies with me and Teddy. I love him so much.

Finally, after days turning into weeks of waiting for an answer on whether he would graduate, the counselors called me in and told me the most amazing thing, he passed.

I was so excited for him. He worked so hard, and he finally made it. I called his father and let him know the good news and went straight to work trying to find out what college he would go to. But then he surprised me (he was always so good at that.) When I brought up the colleges, he showed me a handful of pamphlets he had picked up from the counselor. She recommended the pamphlets and said they would be good for his future I didn't think he would have already been too interested but he seemed really excited about it.

Summer went by, and I spent it trying to ensure Robbie was prepared to be away from home. The moms in my support group thought I was crazy to send him away so soon, but I brushed them off. Told them it would be good for him to get some real-world experience. He certainly did not need me there his whole life. It's good to give your children some space. But when he left, I don't know, I… I guess I didn't expect it to hit me so hard. I remember I went back to his room and grabbed ahold of Teddy. I couldn't believe he actually left him behind. But he told me he didn't want the other guys making fun of him for carrying around a teddy bear. I could tell that it hurt him to leave Teddy behind, but I promised we would take good care of each other.

Like I said earlier I joined a mom's support group near the end of his senior year. I kind of just did it originally to spend time with my mama friends but now that my baby was gone, they were my support systems. Some of them wept with me while others couldn't help but share

their insight on my baby's plans to leave. I know they didn't think that he could handle it out there, but he tried and that was all that mattered to me.

Somehow, they all concluded that I should write to him. Let him know how I feel. But I didn't need him to worry. I guess technically, I didn't want him to worry. They came up with so many solutions to my grief but none of them worked.

"Mary get a dog" or "Mary, try and plan a trip with your husband." Sure, I could do all of that, but none of it would bring him back here to me. Finally, they tried to reason with me and tried to get me to get my feelings out. I'll never forget what they said. They told me to think back to when he first left and try to think about what I would say to him. "If you could go back in time and tell your son one thing right before he left, what would it be?"

I didn't have an answer for them at the time. I just missed him so much. But now looking back, if I could tell him one thing, I would tell him not to enlist.

I would tell him that me and that counselor would have a few choice words for recommending him to join the army.

I would tell him to not be so excited about those pamphlets because they would end up taking him from me

I would tell him that he was not gonna make a difference in the world and that he wasn't going to prove all of those people at school wrong

I would tell him that his mama was labeled as a killer because of his decision.

I would tell him that his mother has to go back to his room and hold onto that goddamn bear hoping and praying to God that he can hear me when I talk to it

I would tell him that his father and I would hate each other because he didn't want to be married to the person who murdered his son.

But if I could tell him just one thing. I would tell him I'm sorry for being a terrible mother.

He came to me with those pamphlets one day and I just saw one thing:

"U.S Military. We Want You!"

And my selfish heart told him to do it. I was the one who said it would be good for him. He came to me so excited saying that he could make a difference in the world, and I told him yes. Why wouldn't I? There is nothing wrong with a little discipline in a kid's heart and all of his schooling

would have been paid for. Yeah, I said it would be good for him because I am his mother, and I know what is best for him.

When the news came out that he had passed every single one of those women in my group turned on me. Called me evil. Said that no good mother would send their child off to war. But they don't know what they're talking about. Their children were all pretty, popular, honors students who didn't have to worry about their futures. They didn't have to worry about affording college because they all had financial aid. They didn't have to sit back and watch every last one

of their classmates exclude them from everything, to where they don't think they have a purpose in life.

So yeah, I said yes. I said the army would have been good for him. Wouldn't you all have said that if your child was struggling in school? If you were scared that if they didn't find this "life purpose" then they would want to try and end their life? And yeah, I technically don't owe any of you an explanation on my parenting, but I will tell you... that before you all jump in and criticize me just know that if I had known what was gonna happen to my sweet little angel baby then I wouldn't have sent him off. I may not be a perfect mother, but I am still his mother. Not you, not any of you. You didn't know him like I did and if any of you were in my shoes you would have said the exact same thing.

The people in my group and at church would tell me that he was in a better place. That this was all a part of God's plan. But you know what, I am done with hearing that. I have been praying and giving back to the church for as long as I can remember and yet this is what happens. All of my time and energy went into serving my family and my community for the sake of God and this is how I am repaid. I am sick of everyone saying it is all a part of God's plan. God planned that he was gonna be bullied his whole life. God planned that he struggled in school. God planned that he would leave my home. God planned that he would pass away. God planned that I was never gonna see him again. If this is all a part of God's plan… then why was his plan to make me more miserable than anyone I knew? He could have done this to anyone why did he have to choose me and my family? It was his way of telling me I was not a good enough Christian, a good enough mother, or a good enough person. I tried but I failed. And that in God's mind, I am a disappointment.

You know… I'm not mad at him. Why would I be? It wasn't his fault. I'm not mad at all of those people who I thought had my back when he died. I'm not mad at those counselors or classmates who made him want to join the army. Heck, I'm not even mad at the army. People told me to channel my anger at them but why would I? They fight for a good cause that my son wanted to be a part of. They didn't know that he was destined to die. I'm not even mad at his father for the divorce.

If anything,… I'm mad at myself.

I'm not perfect, I don't claim to be perfect or a perfect mom. I made a mistake. I ruined lives because I made one simple mistake. I said yes. I could have said no and found a way to help him pay for college and get him more involved in the community. But then I would have been accused of "coddling him." Forget that. I don't care what they think. I care about him. And I know that if I could give anything, I would give my whole life to the Lord if it meant that he was here, and I wasn't.

A killer must be punished, and I was. I killed my son. My one reason for living is gone. So, I guess I deserve it.

(to Teddy) It's just you and me bud. I am so sorry I killed your best friend. I didn't mean to, but I did and I am so sorry. I miss him too, but all we have is each other. And you know what… I'm happy with that. I think you know Robert better than anyone in this world. You always had an easier time getting him to open up than I did. You two were brothers. Could you tell me about him?